It's OK, the doctor said. *It's OK.*

She fell again, right at my feet.

Goodnight, sweet princess.

I looked left, right. No one was near me. The soldiers had all raced back to their trucks. The one with the AK-47 was rolling up the window. Even Billy the Rock had taken a half-step back.

The doctor said, *Sorry about that.*

Don't be.

We returned to camp. Everyone climbed into their tents, their trucks, except me.

I returned to my mat by the fire.

You're joking, they all said. *What about the lions? We just saw proof that there are lions out here, boss.*

Pff. Trust me. That lioness isn't going to hurt anybody.

In fact she's probably watching over us.

86.

Back to America. With two good mates. January 2016.

My mate Thomas was dating a woman who lived in Los Angeles, so our first stop was her house. She gave a welcome party, invited a small group of friends over. Everyone was on the same page about alcohol—in other words, committed to consuming large amounts in a short time.

Where we didn't agree was which type.

The typical Brit, I asked for a gin and tonic.

Hell no, the Americans said, laughing. *You're in the States now, pal, have a real drink. Have a tequila.*

I was familiar with tequila. But mostly club tequila. Late-night tequila. What I was being offered now was proper tequila, fancy schmancy tequila, and I was being schooled in all the many ways of drinking it. Glasses were